Unit 3: Replying to an email

Formal emails can be used for a number of purposes, such as to make complaints, place orders, or answer queries. In this unit, you will **write a formal reply email to confirm arrangements**.

In general, formal emails will have six main components:

1. Subject line

The subject line gives the recipient, or the person receiving the email, a quick idea of what they can expect to see in the email. Subject lines should be short, direct, and appropriate to the recipient. Informal language should not be used, unless you are close to the recipient. (Even then, be sure to keep your language appropriate for the situation.) The subject of an email can be stated using one or more keywords. If you are replying to an email, there is usually no need to write a new subject line. For example, if the original subject was: **Upcoming health checkup**, you can just use the subject line automatically generated by your program: **Re: Upcoming health checkup**.

However, you can also add information that you think the recipient should know immediately, such as: **Upcoming health checkup – Schedule conflict**.

2. Salutation

This is a standard pattern of words used to politely address the recipient. Salutations should be on their own line and be followed by a comma The basic pattern is "Dear + recipient", but there are some variations. It is best to try to find out who you are writing back to and what title the person normally uses e.g. Dr., Vice President, or Professor. Many times, people will include their title or pronouns in their emails, social media, or other online accounts, e.g. Brady Kim (Mr.), Avery Halim (she/her). Use these to determine what name and title you will use in the salutation. Avoid "Mrs." unless you are certain the recipient is a married woman *and* uses that title. Note that in some varieties of English, titles do not end with a period.

If the above information is unknown, use a standard formal salutation, e.g. Dear Sir/Madam, or To Whom It May Concern, or the recipient's job title, e.g. Dear Head of Applied Research..

3. Opening sentence

This is where you directly state the purpose of your email. In a reply email, you should always address the points that the original brought up, and usually, in the same order they were presented. If they started the email by talking about a phone call and then asking for information about your education, you should reference the phone call and then offer that information. Be direct, but polite. For example:

- **I am writing in response to your email of February 8, in which you offered me the position of solutions engineer at your company.**
- **Thank you for your telephone call of January 24, during which we spoke about my transfer to Chiang Mai.**

The following are some possible opening sentence starters. Note that you can change "email" to any other form of communication, e.g. phone call, social media exchange, meeting. However, make sure to use the correct prepositions, e.g. With reference to our telephone call on March 3, *during* which …

- I am writing in reply to … / concerning … / with regard to … / about …
- Thank you for your email of May 12, in which you …
- With reference to your email of May 12, …
- In reply to the email you sent on May 12, …
- Further to your email of May 12, …

***Note the format of the date.**

4. Body

This section will have details that expand on or support your opening sentence. The actual parts of the body of each email will differ depending on your purpose in sending the email, but if you are confirming arrangements, make sure to make clear what you will do in response to any issues the email brings up. Make sure to respond to each point that requires a response in the original email. You may have several paragraphs, but make sure that you construct each body paragraph around only one central idea. How many topics does the following example address?

Further to your email of March 28. I am writing to happily accept your offer of an internship position at your company. I look forward to starting the position on June 12. I will be sending physical copies of my passport and TOEFL score report to the address you included by April 23.

However, I will be unable to submit a copy of my university transcript until April 25. That is the earliest that it will be available.

If it is all right, I would like to ask some questions about the orientation. I have read the information that was provided, but I am still confused about several points.

5. Conclusion

The conclusion typically contains one or two sentences to end the email. What you write in the conclusion will depend on the purpose of the email. In general, you can ask yourself the following question: *What do you want to happen next?* For example, if you are going to meet the recipient online, you would assure them that you will be there. Therefore, you could include the following sentence in the conclusion: **I am looking forward to our meeting online on August 26.**

This makes it clear that you will attend the meeting. It is also a good idea to thank the recipient for anything positive they have said or done for you. For example, if the recipient wrote: **I have converted the documents to PDF format for you**, you can include in your conclusion: **Thank you so much for converting the documents to PDF for me.**

6. Complimentary close

This is the part that comes before your name and the end of the email. Like the salutation, there are certain set patterns that depend on your relationship with the recipient. The most common complimentary close phrases are:

Sincerely,	Respectfully,	Yours faithfully,
Yours sincerely,	Best regards,	Kind regards,

***Note the use of commas.**

Remember that these six components of a formal email can be changed or customized to the type of email you are writing or responding to. For instance, if you are close to the recipient, you can change the formality of your language. Furthermore, additional components may be included, such as attachments. If sending attachments, these should be referred to in the email body, e.g.: **Please find attached a copy of my university transcript. / I have attached the receipt for my seminar registration.**

Exercise 1. Choose the sentence in each pair that is more polite.

1.

A. Please prepare several topics related to your field of interest to discuss.
B. Prepare several topics related to your field of interest to discuss.

2.

A. If you could have the report ready by Friday, it would be very much appreciated.
B. Have the report ready by Friday.

3.

A. Would it be possible to ask for a different room?
B. I would like a different room.

Exercise 2. Complete the following suggestions regarding polite language by circling the correct option.

1. In most cases, being **direct / indirect** is the more polite option (e.g. *Do you think that meeting at 9 AM might be better?* is more polite than *Meeting at 9 AM is better.*)
2. Since telling someone to do something could be considered rude, it is better to use **questions or suggestions** / **commands or warnings** (e.g. *Would it be all right to leave early?*, *It is suggested you leave at 9 AM.*)
3. **Use** / **do not use** *please*, as well as *if you could please*. Offer thanks as often as needed.
4. When possible, use the **active voice** / **passive voice** (e.g. *The contract should be read carefully* is better than *Read the contract carefully*).
5. Using certain **modals** / **articles** can help increase politeness (e.g. *I might need to book a suite* is more polite than *I will book a suite*).

Exercise 3. Read the following email. Rearrange the components of Hitoshi's response into the best order for a reply email. In addition, add an appropriate salutation (1) and complimentary close (2).

To: hitoshi.sakamura@sendai.ac.jp
Cc: Melody
Date sent: December 3
Subject: Application to Create the Future
Dear Hitoshi, Thank you for submitting your application to be a contestant on "Create the Future". We are pleased to inform you that you have been successful. Congratulations! We would like you to be on our television series, which will be filming in early February. As mentioned on our website, we will be providing accommodation for you during the entire filming period. You will be staying with an assigned roommate. If this does not work for you, please inform us. However, please be advised that if you cannot stay with another person, you must pay 50% of the accommodation fee. Please also inform us of any special requirements you have. In addition, we would be happy to help you with applying for a temporary work permit. This will be needed as you are a non-Australian citizen. Might I suggest you begin the work permit application process as soon as possible? Melody, who is our production assistant, can guide you and answer all your questions. She has been copied on this email, so you can contact her directly. Finally, please attach a photograph of yourself that we can use for promotion on our social media accounts. The photograph should show you facing forward and not wearing any headgear. The recommended size is 2400x1600px. If you have any further questions, please do not hesitate to contact us. We look forward to meeting you soon. We believe you will be a valuable addition to our series. Best regards, Sheila Tanner (she/her) Executive producer

To: s.tanner@futureproductions.com
Cc:
Date sent: December 4
Subject: Re: Application to Create the Future
Attach: photo.jpg
1. _____
A. In addition, as requested in your email, I have attached a photograph of myself. It follows your instructions and is the recommended size.
B. I am writing in reply to your email of December 3. Thank you for accepting my application. I am excited to be on the program.
C. I will need some help with applying for a temporary work permit, and I will be in contact with Melody as soon as possible. Again, thank you for the assistance. Unfortunately, due to some family issues, I will not be able to start the application process until late January. I hope that this will be all right.
D. Please let me say thank you again for giving me this amazing opportunity. I look forward to meeting you soon as well.
E. Regarding the accommodation issue, I have no problem staying with a roommate. However, would it be all right to ask for a non-smoking roommate? I have asthma, and being near a smoker would be difficult for me. Thank you for your understanding.
2. _____ Hitoshi Sakamura (he/him)

What is the correct order of the components?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____